Production Incident Response and Triage Runbook

FICTIONAL TRAINING DOCUMENT — designed for RAG/agent testing; no real company, policy, SLA, customer, or price is represented.

Severity

Sev	Definition / examples
1	Critical widespread outage, credible data-loss risk, security-impacting failure; e.g. multi-region login outage.
2	Major degradation with substantial impact; e.g. single-region API unavailable or queue stopped.
3	Limited subset of customers/features.
4	Minor defect with workaround/cosmetic/non-production issue.

First 15 minutes

• Confirm report with independent signals; define service, region, tenant count, endpoint and start time.

• Assign Incident Commander for Sev 1/2; freeze unrelated risky changes when appropriate.

• Check deployments/config, dependency health, capacity; start UTC timeline.

• Choose fastest safe mitigation: rollback, failover, feature disable, load shedding, scaling.

Restore safe service before proving root cause. Preserve evidence, but do not delay a low-risk known-good rollback solely to complete diagnosis.

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Incident Commander	Coordination, priorities, decisions, handoffs
Technical Lead	Diagnosis and mitigation
Communications Lead	Internal/customer updates
Scribe	Timeline, observations, actions, decisions
SME	Specific service/dependency investigation

Investigation sequence

Health metrics → deployment/config timeline → logs/traces/request IDs → database connections/locks/replication/queries → queues/workers/dead letters → identity/email/payment/storage/network dependencies → tenant/region comparison.

Mitigation

Rollback when impact closely follows a release and prior version is known-good. Feature flags isolate optional failing paths. Regional failover requires verified replication/dependency readiness. Scaling can worsen downstream pressure when the bottleneck is database or dependency capacity.

Communication

Severity	Customer cadence
Sev 1	Every 30 min until stable; hourly in monitoring
Sev 2	At least every 2 hours or material change
Sev 3	Via support case as needed
Sev 4	Normal support workflow

Recovery criteria

• Primary customer function restored; error/latency back to normal or accepted temporary threshold.

• Backlogs draining without retry storm; consistency checks show no unresolved corruption risk.

• Stable monitoring for an appropriate observation window.

Post-incident review

Sev 1 and significant Sev 2 incidents require review within five business days: impact, timeline, contributing factors, root cause when known, detection gaps, mitigation, and tracked corrective actions. Focus is system improvement.

Billing dependency

Technical records verified incident start/end, affected services/regions, and outage vs degradation. Billing decides contractual eligibility and credit amount. Engineers must not promise monetary compensation.

Worked incident

14:02 UTC: EU write-API errors rise to 18% after release 2026.10.184. 14:07: Sev 2 declared. Previous release verified healthy; rollback starts 14:14. Errors fall below 1% by 14:20. Monitor 30 minutes. Record verified impact window 14:02-14:20 for Billing review.

Closure evidence

• Incident ID/severity; timeline; dashboards and representative request IDs.

• Mitigation/rollback version; backlog/data-consistency state.

• Customer communication history and confirmed impact window.